

Day 1 — Hook: A Persistent Question

Module: Pañcabhūta (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students articulate what “categorising matter” means and identify three distinct historical frameworks for doing it.

Materials

- Whiteboard
- Periodic table poster
- Printed copy of SB 2.10.3 with IAST + translation (from cache)

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Opening provocation on board: “*Categories are not in nature. Categories are imposed on nature. Discuss.*”

Take 3 student responses.

Core (25 min)

1. **Three frameworks, one question.** Write on board:

Framework	Approximate date	Categories
Greek (Empedocles, Aristotle)	5th c. BCE → 4th c. BCE	4 + 1 (quintessence)
Sāṅkhya (India)	likely pre-5th c. BCE, codified c. 4th c. CE	25 tattvas (5 are bhūtas)
Modern periodic table	1869 (Mendeleev) → present	118+ elements

2. **The persistent question:** “*What categories of stuff (and not-stuff) does the world come in?*” Every culture’s natural philosophers tried to answer this. The answers differ because the methods differ and the questions are framed differently.
3. **Today’s anchor verse — SB 2.10.3.** Read in IAST. Then translation: > “*bhūta-mātrendṛya-dhiyām janma sarga udāhṛtaḥ ...*” > “The manifestation of the gross elements, the senses, and the intellect is called creation (*sarga*).”

Note the move: the Sāṅkhya verse names the bhūtas (elements), the indriyas (senses), and the dhī (intellect) as products of a single creation event. Modern science talks about atoms; Sāṅkhya talks about a unified scheme that includes the *perceiver*. This is a real structural difference, not just terminology.

Discussion (10 min)

Open question: “*Is the modern periodic table ‘more correct’ than Empedocles’ four elements? More correct in what way?*”

- Let students argue.
- Reinforce: a framework can be more *predictive* (chemistry, atomic structure) without being more *comprehensive* (the Sāṅkhya scheme includes consciousness; modern chemistry doesn’t claim to).

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 2: “*Tomorrow we map out the full 25-tattva ladder of Sāṅkhya. The five elements are only the LAST five.*”
- Homework: read the SB 2.10.3 cache entry in full. Note one question you have.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read Kirk, Raven & Schofield’s intro on Empedocles. Be ready to present on Day 4.
- **Tier down:** Stick to the framework-comparison; the primary-source reading deepens on Day 5.

Teacher notes

- Don’t let “modern science is just objectively right” be the resting position. Push: “what does objectively right *mean*? Predictive accuracy? Comprehensiveness? Explanatory power?”
- This module is about *intellectual honesty across frameworks*, not about advocacy for any one of them.

Citation(s) used

- SB 2.10.3 — vidya-karana RAG cache day-01-hook.json#chunks[0]